the war as quickly as possible or to what extent it was an act of ‘atomic diplomacy’ to intimidate the Soviet Union. Hiroshima and Nagasaki will, forever, be linked together in the history of war. Yet their fates were sealed in very different ways. The bombing of Nagasaki illustrates various themes in Cold War nuclear history and in the Cuban missile crisis.

In May 1945, three Japanese cities were earmarked for attack: Kyoto, Hiroshima and Niigata. In late June Kokura completed the target list.[40] When Franklin Roosevelt died on 12 April 1945, Vice President Truman knew nothing about the Manhattan Project to build the atomic bomb. It seems clear he never fully made it to the top of the steep learning curve that he faced.

While Truman’s officials debated options for dropping the bomb during the summer of 1945, the President never doubted that it should be used. The target list was drawn up by his officials, but in July he was nevertheless called upon to decide which city to attack (or rather which city not to attack). Truman was at the Potsdam conference with Churchill, Stalin and Chiang Kai-shek when a plutonium device was successfully exploded in the New Mexico desert on 25 July 1945. His Secretary of State for War, Henry Stimson, provided him with details.

The eighty-three-year-old Stimson had another reason for being in Potsdam. He wanted to persuade Truman not to drop the atomic bomb on Kyoto, the ancient capital of Japan, a spiritual home of Shintoism and Buddhism, with a population of a million people. Kyoto was the priority target. The secretary of state, however, had deep misgivings about the morality of the US air war on Japan, he had visited Kyoto before the war, and he also worried about the post-war consequences for US-Japanese relations, including the risk that Tokyo might gravitate towards Moscow. Senior officials in Washington, on the other hand, were keen to attack the old capital. It was a cultural and intellectual centre of Japanese society whose destruction would yield the psychological impact on Japan’s leaders that many of Truman’s advisers in Washington sought. It also contained important military and industrial installations.

Henry Stimson succeeded in his mission and thereby saved the people of Kyoto from the atomic bomb. Truman provided an account of their